asking the governor to sign the University Law Amendment Bill that seeks to curtail the Raj Bhavan's powers in appointing V-Cs. Two days earlier, in his capacity as the chancellor of state universities, the governor had removed 15 members of Kerala University's senate for not sending their nominee's name for the VC's selection committee.

The conflict spiralled into a bigger storm when the governor asked the V-Cs of 11 state universities to resign as their appointment process did not follow the procedure laid down by the University Grants Commission (UGC)—the selection committee is required to send three names for the governor's approval, but had sent only one. The governor issued the order after the Supreme Court annulled the appointment of M.S. Rajasree as the V-C of the A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Technological University on the same ground.

The friction between Khan and the Pinarayi government also had its roots in a V-C appointment last year when the governor resisted the reappointment of Gopinath Ravindran as the V-C of Kannur University. The bitterness intensified with Khan calling Ravindran a "criminal" who had allegedly plotted protests against Khan in 2019.

KERALA CM PINARAYI VIJAYAN WARNED GOVERNOR ARIF MOHAMMAD KHAN AGAINST CROSSING THE LIMITS OF HIS POWERS



Photographs by ANI

His current action against the V-Cs was met with stiff resistance—nobody resigned—and CM Vijayan issued a stern warning to Khan asking him not to cross the limits of his powers. In response, the governor issued show-cause notices to the V-Cs asking them to respond by November 3 even as they moved the Kerala High Court against his directive.

The tussle in Kerala between the governor and the government has once again ignited a heated debate on the former's role in India's federal structure. If such debates were triggered in the past by the governor's discretion in the appointment and dismissal of chief ministers in the states, in recent times, the conflicts between governors and elected state governments have now moved to other functions related to governance such as determining the time for convening the assembly, demanding information about day-to-day administration, delaying assent to bills or reserving the bills for the President and making adverse comments in public.

For instance, a row broke out in October when Punjab Governor Banwarilal Purohit withdrew his consent for a special session convened by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann to table a motion of confidence. Similar refusals to give consent for convening a special assembly session were also seen in Kerala and Rajasthan in